

From Baul to Dylan: Folk Music Aesthetics

TAY

ENG110: Literature for Life

Baul and Lalon Geeti

- Some scholars believe that the Baul movement stemmed from Birbhadra, the son and disciple of Vaishnavite saint Nityanand.
- It dates back to the 15th century
- “According to one theory, it is believed that the Baul movement may have originated from the Bhakti Movement that engulfed India in the period between 14th and 17th century. The movement originated in South India, but spread up to North India. Famous people associated with the Bhakti movement and who helped spread it from South India to the North include Ravidas, Shri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, Meera Bai, Surdas, Kabir, Tulsidas, Tukaram and several others (Haque)” (Flame University, p.2)

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- unorthodox and devoid of any religion or caste system
- nomadic and melodic tune
- “The Bengali folk music is always considered as ‘distant’ from the civil life and ‘rooted’ in the pastoral life of local people with the characteristic of ‘exclusively’ traditional genre.” (p.6)
- streams of equity, secularism, humanity and spirituality
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-_8wq-Z4ykM&authuser=1
- <https://ajabshahar.com/songs/details/43/Sri-Choron-Paabo&title=Sri-Choron-Paabo>

Lalon's Philosophy

1. Follows *Dehattya* (truth in the body)
2. Based on *Tantric* traditions (esoteric practice) of different religions
3. Quests for keeping unity and the bondage between people.

Baulism

1. Considered as a 'complete code of life'
2. Emphasizes on a person's physical body.
3. *Akhra* as a 'school of brotherhood' for *baul* followers
4. A hierarchical relationship between *murshid* (guru) and *shishwa* (disciple)

Baul Musical Tradition

1. Reflects *baul* philosophy
2. Mystical music
3. Bodily movement, termed as *baul* dance
4. Provides liberal interpretations of life, love, religion and nature

Lalon Fakir & Kangalini Sufia

- “Caste is Lost”
- “I have aged because of you”

What Baul Music Primarily Focuses on

- Material world to be filled with incoherence and disorder
- Deep connection with the land, the divine, and nature
- Shadhana: A prolonged mindful practice of manifestation, longing, and understanding the self in relation to the Divine
- Belief system circulating around “Manob Dhormo”
- The neglect of the working class
- The spirituality and the loss of spirituality due to the systemic oppression towards working class

Bob Dylan

- named initially Robert Allen Zimmerman, Dylan had a profound connection with culture, music, and social revolution
- Fascinated by Beat poetry and folksinger Woody Guthrie, he began performing folk music in coffeehouses, adopting the last name Dylan.
- In April 1963, Dylan played his first major New York City concert at Town Hall. Crowned as the king of folk music
- Besides his large production of albums, Dylan has published experimental work like the prose poetry collection Tarantula (1971)
- In 2016, he won the Nobel Prize for Literature, “for having created new poetic expressions within the great American song tradition.”
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jWuk_R2_lu4
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KpD26loRLvA>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FmbwU3J-2kk>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MCjGSbm2LFC>

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- <https://www.nobelprize.org/prizes/literature/2016/dylan/lecture/>

“Our songs are alive in the land of the living. But songs are unlike literature. They’re meant to be sung, not read. The words in Shakespeare’s plays were meant to be acted on the stage. Just as lyrics in songs are meant to be sung, not read on a page. And I hope some of you get the chance to listen to these lyrics the way they were intended to be heard: in concert or on record or however people are listening to songs these days. I return once again to Homer, who says, “Sing in me, oh Muse, and through me tell the story.”

The Times They Are-A Changin'

- 1963, the night after the assassination of John F Kennedy
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Only a Pawn In Their Game

- <https://www.zinnedproject.org/news/tdih/medgar-evers-murdered/#:~:text=On%20June%2012%2C%201963%2C%20Medgar,home%5D%20fighting%E2%80%9D%20for%20change.>
- Integration into colonial society required a transformation in one's body. The body became not an object but a changeable subject, whose "skin, which has either been naturalized or born here, is assumed to not belong here – in this place, in this land, within this topography. The historical and social meaning of race in a location dislocates certain bodies" (Sundstrom & Kim, 2014, p. 28).
- <https://turia.uv.es//index.php/Hybrida/article/view/26240/22752#:~:text=Fanon%20illustrated%20the%20injustice%20and,the%20status%20of%20the%20Other.>

Antonio Gramsci's Notion of Hegemony

- “I hate the indifferent” –from his essay *Odio gli indifferenti*, 1917

<https://www.goodreads.com/quotes/849434-i-hate-the-indifferent-i-believe-that-living-means-taking>

Baul and Dylan

- Impact of music in terms of spirituality
- Resilience and Revolution
- Western VS South Asian folk tradition

CHECK CLASS NOTES